played an important role in facilitating his appointment as WFI president in 2011. This explains Singh's connections across party lines as well as the fact that Mulayam's son and SP chief, Akhilesh Yadav, has remained almost silent on the current controversy even though his ally, Rashtriya Lok Dal chief Jayant Chaudhary, went to Jantar Mantar in support of the protesting wrestlers. Singh has built his influence in other ways too. There are 54 educational institutions across four districts that he either runs or is associated with (see *Why He was Feared and Loathed*).

A wrestling coach from UP who chose to remain anonymous says that Singh used his clout to ensure that WFI was never short on funds and maintained its Category I ranking with the Sports Authority of India (SAI). Singh, however, he reveals, was known to be "rude", respecting neither coaches nor players. "*Photo khinchaane tak* respect *thi* [his respect was limited to photo-ops]," he adds. In a viral video, the six-time Lok Sabha MP was seen slapping a slightly-built, young male wrestler during a national championship in Ranchi in 2021. Singh defended his action saying he lost his temper as the player was guilty of age fraud and insisted on being given another chance. Congress Rajya Sabha MP Deepender Hooda, an erstwhile president of the Haryana Wrestling Association, claims he was made familiar with Singh's "*tanashahi*" by miffed wrestlers who reached out to him a few years back. Hooda confronted Singh with the charges, which included random selection and dropping of wrestlers. At the WFI, Hooda alleges that Singh installed his loyalists in most of the state units to ensure complete control. "Whether he contests or not, he can make anybody president. It has become his *benami* property," he says.

Quite in sync with all the dust he has kicked up outside his home turf, Singh is regarded as a bahubali by the people of Gonda district in UP. There is no telling if it's out of fear or veneration. Says his lawyer A.P. Singh: "The accusers/complainants are internationally recognised wrestlers who possess physical strength and financial stability. It is difficult to believe they could be subjected to harassment by a 66-year-old man. Other wrestlers, too, are politically motivated. We are sure that he will get a clean chit on the issue." With so many under his sway, it's no surprise that Singh remains defiant, going about as if it's business as usual. From April 16-18, the National Championships in the under-17 category as well as the Senior Open National Ranking Wrestling Tournament were held in his bastion in Nawabganj. The venue was Nandini Nagar Mahavidyalaya, the first college Singh set up, in 1990, of which he is the chairperson. For the protesting wrestlers, this was a betrayal after the government assured them that Singh would be no longer at the helm. They chose to return to the protest site and also to seek legal counsel from advocate Narendra Hooda.



AP

**The Mary Kom committee had two recommendations: set up an ad hoc committee to run WFI and ask Delhi Police to investigate**

## THE LEGAL TRAJECTORY

It was not as though the wheels of justice had not been moving, they were just moving too slowly for the wrestlers' liking. A day after they began their protest at Jantar Mantar on January 18, Union sports and youth affairs minister Anurag Thakur met them and, two days later, announced a six-member Oversight Committee (OC) headed by renowned boxer Mary Kom to look into the allegations. The Mary Kom committee, which was asked to submit its report in a month asked for two extensions. This was because, as Thakur says, "the committee was very open and listened patiently to each one they met." (See *'We believe in a transparent, timely probe'.*)

The OC submitted its report on April 5, but it has not been made public so far. Clarifying why this is so, Thakur says the matter is sensitive, and they have handed the report to the police who are investigating the matter. Thakur also says it is up to the courts to decide whether it should be made public or not. The one finding that has been disclosed red-flags the fact that the WFI did not have a PoSH Act-mandated ICC. The